

tion, but have Web sites that are able to provide cutting edge news bites and interactive features, which measure user needs and satisfaction.

Is it the best use of my staff time and resources?

Industryview.com, which promotes business information and corporate profiles through the innovative use of videos, has this to say: "Businesses must communicate! The right medium for one company may not be right for another. It all depends on the scope and objectives of a marketing plan." Industryview.com, which is based in the US, illustrates, through comparison, the costs and benefits of media services that are used to communicate corporate information.

The table below offers a cost comparison of traditional print brochures versus streaming media. Streaming media is often misunderstood

Print vs Video

	Marketing brochure	Streaming profile
Description	2-page multi-colour	2-minute low-end video
Creation cost	Rs 2,000	Rs 4,000
Audience/copies	10,000	10,000
Postage/distribution	Rs 60,000	Rs 25,000
Printing costs	Rs 35,000	-
Response rates	Varied based on delivery method	Measured directly as actual viewers
Total Cost	Rs 97,000	Rs 29,000

cards for analogue camcorders. Note that video consumes tons of space when converted into digital data. Also, capture video at the correct resolution—capturing at a resolution of 640 x 480, and then resizing it to 352 x 288, amounts to you doing the entire job twice.

Your PC should have enough processing power, memory and hard disk space to deal with video jobs. You may not need a top-of-the-line system, but a current generation system is recommended.

Equally important is the software you will need to edit and compress your video. Depending on the amount of video that you capture, and the way you transfer it to your computer, you can use software such as Ulead VideoStudio 8 or Adobe Premiere. These offer integrated solutions that let you capture video from the source and transfer them to your hard drive. You can edit them, add your effects, put in an audio track, watermark your videos, and compress them to formats such as Quicktime and RealMedia.

Conclusion

Technicalities and price tags aside, using video cameras in your office, though a relatively new idea today, can serve a substantial number of purposes for any business house: Orienting recruits in one mere hour; archiving invaluable presentations and meetings; promoting business in a visually maverick style; reliving moments of fun in office, and much more. Simple and incredible as it sounds, all you need is a video camera for the office to make this magic happen.■

digit@thinkdigit.com

as a service that is either too expensive, or only meant for larger companies. The example below illustrates that a streaming video product can, in many cases, be less expensive and more effective than its print counterpart.

So what do I need?

First, you need a video camera. With various models to choose from, there is a wide range of prices. Sony offers a series of models for the mini-DV format, ranging from Rs 22,760 to Rs 45,520. A Canon mini-DV format camcorder costs anywhere between Rs 36,420 and Rs 2,04,840. For the JVC, Sharp and Panasonic models of the same mini-DV format, prices range from a modest Rs 12,750 to Rs 36,420. While Sony offers its DV Handycam for Rs 41,250 to Rs 45,520, Panasonic's DV camcorders range from Rs 35,280 to Rs 39,140.

You may need additional hardware—Firewire cards for digital cameras, or analogue capture

Video broadcasts that take the form of Web casts make for a formidable option of communication when you have employees scattered all across the globe

Photographs: Mery Xavier, Imaging: Solomon Lewis

Suggested reading

- <http://www.mediatechpro.com/uses.htm>
- The Next Generation of Corporate Communications—Jon Leland
- Why Corporations are using interactive multimedia for sales, marketing and training—Traci Hukill—E Times.com
- Better, Bigger, Faster—Seana Mulcahy.
- Work—Stephen Porter. 2003
- Networked Multimedia-Video Applications: Are we crossing the chasm?—Christine Perey—Business Communications Review, March 1999